

Ease of installation

The installation utility was evaluated for ease-of-use. Special points were given to those flavours that took into account existing Windows partitions, and suggested mount points automatically. The ability of the partitioning utility to handle NTFS, and FAT32 partitions, was considered as a distinct advantage.

Suitability to Desktop

These tests gauged the ease with which a novice can configure, and get around his Linux desktop—for example, easily understandable desktop icons (My Computer, My Presentations, My Documents, etc.), which promote a familiar Windows environment. We also noted the ease with which a user could alter the desktop settings. Simple tasks such as setting the background image, changing screensavers, changing the default desktop resolution, etc., were taken into consideration.

Adherence to the File Hierarchy Standard (FHS) was also given special attention—for interoperability of applications between various Linux distributions.

The number of file systems supported by a Linux box, is a good indication of its suitability in a heterogeneous environment where it needs to co-exist with other operating systems. However, for the typical home, and office

desktop user, the area of major concern is the compatibility level between Linux, and Windows.

Office productivity tools

Office applications such as word processors, spreadsheets, presentation tools, etc., were evaluated, and their compatibility with standard Windows office applications was also determined.

For those who insist on using MS Office tools in Linux, Windows emulators are a viable option. They create an artificial Windows environment within Linux, thereby enabling a user to install, and run his favourite Windows application.

Hardware compatibility

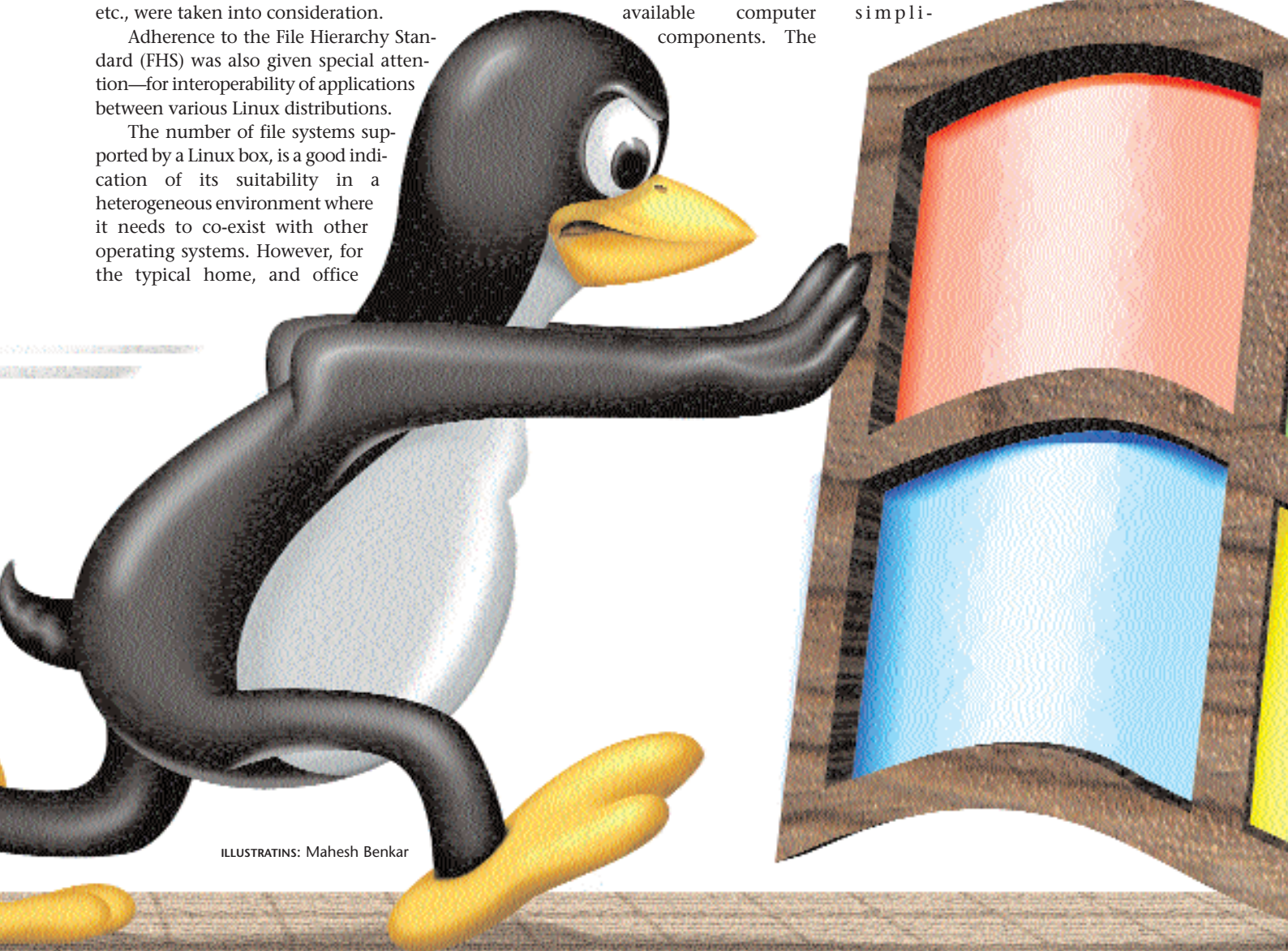
To check the compatibility of the available distros with common hardware, we installed each flavour on 5 different test PCs that represented a pool of popularly available computer components. The

details of each configuration can be found in the hardware compatibility table.

The Windows killers

ELX Linux Power Desktop 2.0: This one is for everyone

The ELX installation was fairly simple. A neat listing of the steps involved on the left hand pane went hand in hand with an information box in the corner. Three install options—Default, Laptop, and Custom System—are offered. The Default install loads a majority of the applications, the Laptop loads only the bare necessities and the Custom install, as the name suggests, is just that. The partitioning utility is similar to that of Red Hat—the user has to assign the root partition. However, the assignment process is simple—



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